

Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) in Milan, Italy



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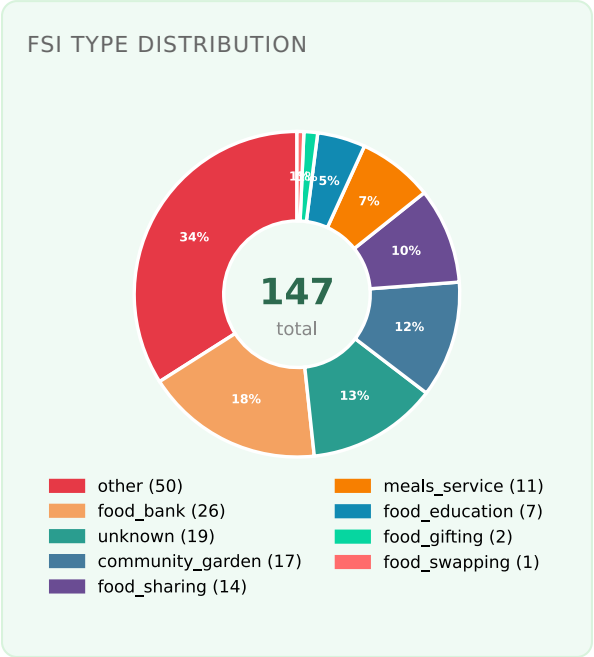
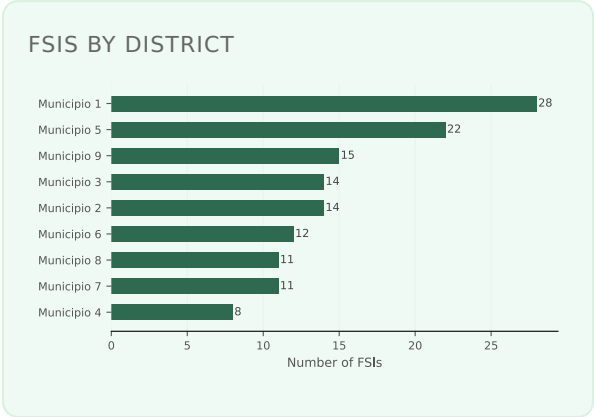
Io non butto - CSV Lombardia
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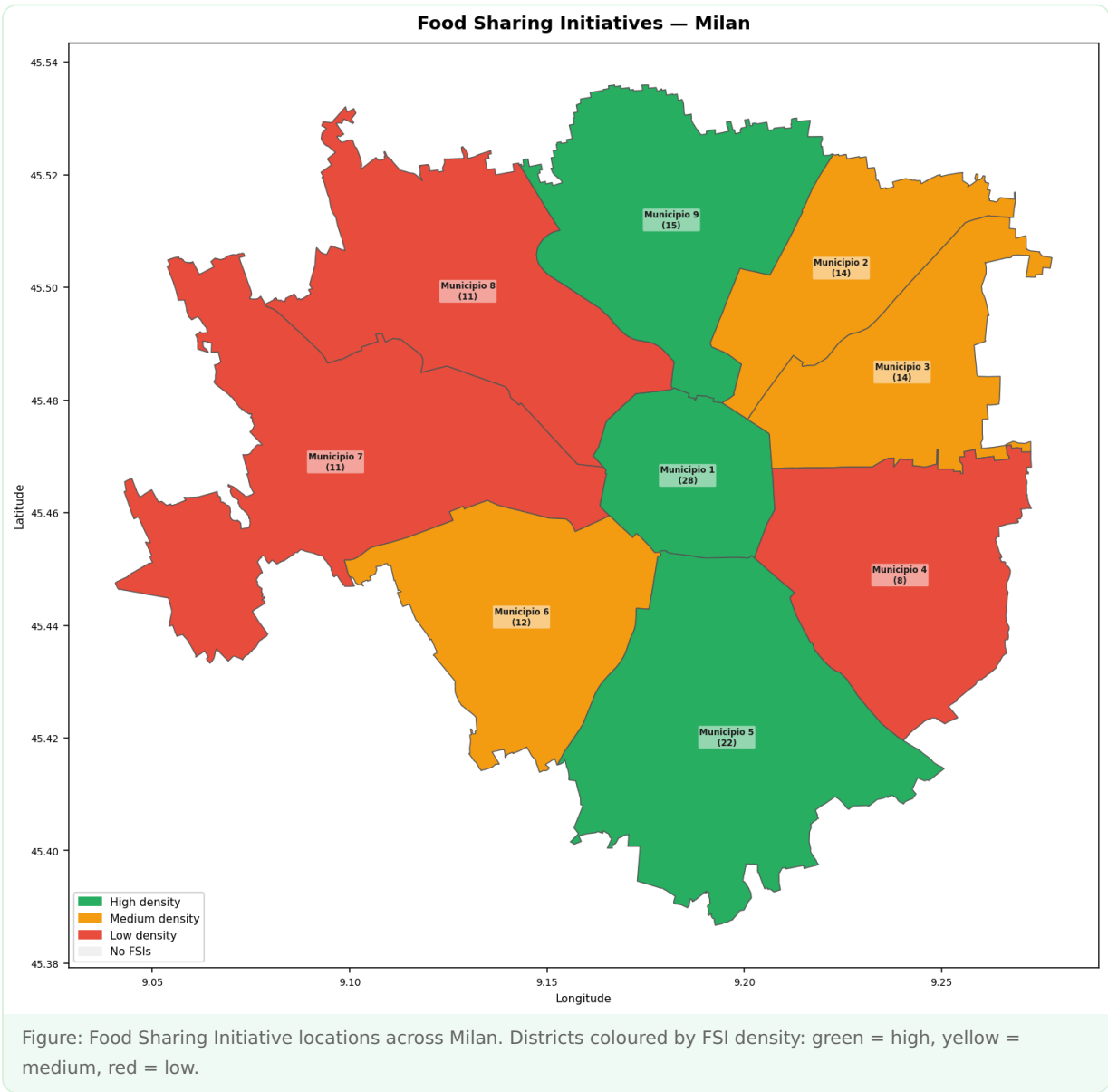
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Geographic Distribution



Milan hosts 147 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) across nine postal districts, with the highest concentrations in Municipio 1 (28 FSIs), Municipio 5 (22 FSIs), and Municipio 9 (15 FSIs), which collectively account for 34% of all initiatives. These three districts, designated as "green" (high-density), exhibit the most significant activity, reflecting a pattern of clustering in areas with established social infrastructure. No district has fewer than eight FSIs, with the lowest count recorded in Municipio 4 (8 FSIs), a "red" (low-density) district. The distribution underscores a disparity between central and peripheral areas, with green districts hosting over twice as many initiatives per district compared to red districts.

Comparing sub-groups, green districts (Municipio 1, 5, 9) maintain the highest density, while yellow (medium-density) districts (Municipio 3, 2, 6) and red districts (Municipio 8, 7, 4) show progressively lower counts, with yellow districts averaging 14 FSIs per district and red districts averaging 11. This gradient suggests a correlation between district classification and initiative density, though the data gap regarding per capita FSI density—

dependent on census population data—limits conclusions about equity in access. Notably, Municipio 1's 28 FSIs represent the highest single-district total, whereas Municipio 4's 8 FSIs, despite being a low-density area, still exceed the minimum threshold for all districts. The absence of districts with only one FSI highlights a baseline level of activity across Milan, but further analysis is required to assess whether this reflects uniform engagement or systemic underreporting in lower-density areas.

Types of Food Sharing Initiatives

Milan hosts 147 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs), with the largest category being "other" initiatives (50, 34.0%), followed by food banks (26, 17.7%) and community gardens (17, 11.6%). Over half of all FSIs (71, 48.3%) incorporate sustainability as a core focus, while 24 (16.3%) integrate educational components, reflecting a growing emphasis on environmental and social learning. A significant proportion of FSIs (92, 62.6%) organise events or workshops, indicating a strong community engagement strategy. The distribution of initiative types highlights a diverse landscape, with food banks and community gardens serving as key pillars, but the "other" category's dominance suggests a broad range of unclassified or hybrid models.

Comparing sub-groups, food banks (26) outnumber community gardens (17) by 34.0% to 11.6%, yet both categories contribute to food insecurity mitigation through distinct approaches. Sustainability-focused FSIs (71) are more prevalent than those with educational components (24), though the latter's smaller size may reflect niche or overlapping objectives. Notably, 92 FSIs hosting events or workshops suggest a deliberate effort to foster participation, potentially enhancing outreach and impact. The absence of clear data on the "other" category's activities limits deeper analysis, but the high proportion of sustainability-linked initiatives implies a strategic alignment with Milan's broader environmental goals. These patterns underscore the city's multifaceted approach to food sharing, balancing immediate aid with long-term systemic change.

Operational and Funding Models

Milan hosts 147 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs), with the majority (141) being non-commercial, encompassing voluntary and charitable efforts. Of these, 63 are NGO-led, representing the largest single category, followed by 21 community-led grassroots initiatives and 14 government-funded programs. Only 3 initiatives are council-supported, highlighting a limited direct role for municipal authorities beyond funding. Notably, 5 FSIs explicitly mention reliance on crowdfunding or donations, while none are volunteer-based, underscoring the dominance of structured organizational models over informal participation. The cooperative model is present in 31 initiatives, suggesting a significant emphasis on collective ownership and shared governance structures.

NGO-led initiatives outnumber community-led efforts by more than double (63 vs. 21), reflecting a stronger institutional presence in food sharing compared to grassroots efforts. Among non-commercial FSIs, 48 are formally registered as NGOs or charities, while 3 operate informally, indicating varying levels of legal and administrative integration. Only 6

FSIs are affiliated with known food networks, suggesting limited interconnectivity between initiatives despite overlapping goals. The absence of volunteer-based models contrasts with the prevalence of cooperative structures, implying a preference for organized, sustained participation over ad hoc contributions. This distribution highlights the reliance on institutional frameworks, with government and NGO roles dominating, while community-led efforts remain relatively small in scale but potentially more localized in impact.

Reach and Activity

Milan hosts 104 high-activity food sharing initiatives (FSIs), representing the majority of all quantified FSIs in the city, while 43 low-activity FSIs remain operational, indicating a stark disparity in engagement levels. Collectively, these initiatives reference a total volume of 31,308 units of food, encompassing meals, kilograms, and member contributions, though this figure does not account for unquantified efforts. Notably, 42 FSIs collaborate with farms, restaurants, or stores, suggesting a significant portion of initiatives integrate supply chain partnerships to redistribute surplus food. This collaboration may explain the higher activity levels observed in these groups compared to those without such partnerships.

Among target audiences, elderly-focused initiatives are most prevalent, with 32 FSIs explicitly mentioning this group, followed by students (14) and general audiences (8), while only 2 FSIs target children. This contrast highlights a potential gap in addressing younger demographics, despite the elderly being the largest group served. The absence of medium-activity FSIs suggests a binary distribution between highly active and low-activity initiatives, with no intermediate engagement levels recorded. Initiatives targeting the elderly may benefit from institutional backing or community networks, as seen in programs like "Spesa Sospesa," which require resident participation through structured volunteer commitments. Meanwhile, the limited focus on children may reflect challenges in designing FSIs that align with their needs or access points, though this remains unexplored in the data.

Digital Presence and Accessibility

All 147 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) in Milan have a digital presence, as evidenced by website scraping data, indicating a strong reliance on online platforms for coordination and outreach. Of these, 70 FSIs explicitly mention online or digital coordination methods, suggesting a significant portion integrates technology into their operations. In contrast, only 19 FSIs operate from physical locations, highlighting a disparity between digital and in-person engagement. Furthermore, just 5 FSIs list operating hours or frequency, underscoring a widespread lack of transparency regarding logistical details that could aid user participation.

The data reveals a marked contrast between FSIs with robust digital infrastructure and those with limited operational transparency. While 70 FSIs leverage online coordination, the 19 physical-location FSIs may cater to more localized or community-based activities, though their absence of detailed operating schedules could hinder accessibility. Notably, the lack of consistent accessibility features on FSI websites—such as screen-reader compatibility or

language options—raises concerns about inclusivity, despite cross-lingual processing enabling English summaries of Italian-language content. This gap suggests that while digital presence is universal, the quality and usability of online resources remain uneven, potentially limiting engagement among non-English speakers or individuals with disabilities.

Notable Initiatives

Milan hosts 147 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) in total, with the highest concentrations located in Municipio 1 (28 FSIs), Municipio 5 (22 FSIs), and Municipio 9 (15 FSIs), reflecting uneven geographic distribution across the city. Of these, 104 FSIs are classified as high-popularity, indicating significant community engagement or operational scale, while 24 incorporate educational components such as nutritional training or waste reduction programs. Additionally, 92 FSIs organize events, suggesting a strong emphasis on public outreach and collaboration with local stakeholders. These figures highlight the diversity of FSIs in Milan, ranging from large-scale initiatives with event-based strategies to smaller, education-focused programs targeting specific needs.

The data reveals contrasts between FSIs with educational components and those prioritizing event-based activities: only 16.3% (24/147) integrate educational programs, compared to 62.6% (92/147) that organize events, implying a broader focus on immediate engagement over long-term behavioral change. For instance, initiatives with educational elements often align with programs like nutritional training or waste management workshops, as seen in some Milanese FSIs, whereas event-driven FSIs frequently host food recovery drives or community meals. This disparity may reflect differing resource allocations, with event-based FSIs leveraging partnerships for visibility, while educational FSIs require sustained investment in curriculum development. Notably, 24% of all FSIs (34/147) operate in districts with the highest FSI density, suggesting clustering in areas with greater infrastructure or social demand. These patterns underscore the need for targeted support to balance immediate outreach with systemic education efforts.